terror, and the institution of a national strategy of 'deniability' and 'lies'.

Take the example of Musharraf's ill-conceived venture in Kargil. A fabricated story of 'freedom fighters' was trotted out, and to maintain the cover-up, the bodies of Pakistani soldiers were left behind. Only recently, during November 2010, some figures of casualties in that war have been officially released. It is amazing how one man's miscalculation can put an entire nation into such a mess. The American writer, Bruce Riedel, has clearly brought out that the US helped to bail out the Pakistan Army and gave them a face-saving opportunity at that time.

The policy of running with the hares and hunting with the hounds has thoroughly discredited Pakistan not only in the eyes of the world but also of their beneficiaries – the Taliban – who claim that the Pakistanis 'feed them with one hand and kill them with the other'. When the sordid tale of nuclear proliferation was exposed, they made A.Q. Khan the fall guy. The most recent nail in the coffin of lies has been the shocking discovery of Osama Bin Laden in the garrison town of Abbotabad, a stone's throw from Pakistani military academy at Kakul. But for the audacious, secretive and highly professional Operation Geronimo, the Pakistani establishment would have continued to put wool over the eyes of the world, as has been asserted by US Congressmen Dana Rohrabacher and Ted Poe. As brilliantly summed up by Cyril Almeida, a well-known Pakistani writer, 'If we didn't know [bin Laden was in Abbotabad], we are a failed state; if we did know, we are a rogue state,' (in a lead article, *Time* Magazine, 13 May 2011). This was perhaps another legacy left behind by Pervez Musharraf's regime.

Taking a realistic and rational view of the factors discussed above, it is very likely that despite the wishes of the US, India, China or the rest of the world to see a stable and prosperous Pakistan, it might still implode. In fact, I went to the extent of telling Cohen that the button for self-destruction might have already been pressed. Only the people of Pakistan could save their country by snapping the already-lit fuse cord before it reached the detonator, and arrest the downward slide into chaos and destruction. The reactions of Cohen